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DEMOCRACY

"If a problem has no solution, it may not be a problem, but a fact—not to be solved, but to be coped with over time."

Shimon Peres

It was not yet dawn on 31 July when 18-month-old Ali Dawabsheh was burned to death. His family had gone to visit relatives the night before, returning at around 1 am to their home in Douma, a Palestinian village outside of Nablus. They went to bed. Sometime later, a group of masked men smashed the windows and tossed Molotov cocktails inside. They had already torched one house, only to find it empty, so they moved on to the Dawabsheh residence.

Ali's parents Riham and Saad managed to escape the house, their clothes engulfed in flames; both would die from their wounds in the coming weeks. Only his brother Ahmed, four, survived the attack, with burns over nearly two-thirds of his body.

Before they fled, the arsonists took the time to spray-paint two short messages on the walls: the single word *nekamah*, "revenge", beneath a star of David; and the phrase *yechai hamelech hamashiach*, "long live the king, the Messiah," a slogan associated with a branch of the ultra-Orthodox Chabad movement. The attack, reminiscent of Mohammed Abu Khdair's murder a year earlier, was thought to be the work of Jewish militants, and it was widely condemned in Israel. "A nation whose children were burned in the Holocaust needs to do a lot of soul-searching if it bred people who burn other human beings," said Gilad Erdan, the public security minister. President Rivlin and Prime Minister Netanyahu both paid a visit to Ahmed in the hospital (though the latter was given a chilly reception).

Not everyone was convinced, though. On the far right, activists speculated that the arson was the result of a village feud, not the work of